

GST 112

Nigerian Peoples and Culture

Supplementary Modules — 3rd Edition Additions

This document covers three modules found in the 3rd edition course material that were not part of the original core summary: Geopolitical Zones, Languages & Festivals; Origins of the Major Ethnic Groups; and Marriage & Family in Pre-Colonial Nigeria. Read this alongside the main GST112_Summary.pdf.

Geopolitical Zones, Languages, and Festivals

Geopolitical Zones

Nigeria is divided into six geopolitical zones — administrative groupings of states created during General Sani Abacha's regime. The zones were not drawn purely by geography, but grouped states sharing similar ethnic composition and/or political history, to allow more effective allocation of resources across Nigeria's roughly 250 ethnic groups and 525 languages.

- **North West** — Kano, Kaduna, Katsina, Sokoto, Kebbi, Zamfara, Jigawa (Hausa-Fulani dominant)
- **North East** — Adamawa, Bauchi, Borno, Gombe, Taraba, Yobe (largest zone by land area)
- **North Central (Middle Belt)** — Benue, Kogi, Kwara, Nasarawa, Niger, Plateau, plus the FCT; Nigeria's most ethnically diverse zone
- **South West** — Lagos, Ogun, Oyo, Osun, Ondo, Ekiti (Yoruba dominant)
- **South East** — Abia, Anambra, Ebonyi, Enugu, Imo (Igbo dominant)
- **South South (Niger Delta)** — Rivers, Delta, Bayelsa, Cross River, Akwa Ibom, Edo (Ijaw, Efik, Ibibio, Urhobo, Edo, and other minorities)

Note: The zones have no constitutional backing. Groups such as the Afenifere Renewal Movement, Ohaneze Ndigbo, and the Ijaw National Congress have campaigned for the six zones to be formally recognized in the constitution as federating units — a live political debate, not settled history.

Language Families

Nigeria's 500+ languages fall into three major families:

- **Niger-Congo** — the largest family by far; includes Yoruba, Igbo, and most southern/middle-belt languages
- **Afro-Asiatic (Chadic branch)** — Hausa belongs here; notably, about 75% of Hausa speakers are non-Hausa, since the language functions as a lingua franca across the North regardless of ethnicity
- **Nilo-Saharan** — the least numerically significant family in Nigeria; its most prominent representative is Kanuri, spoken mainly around Borno

English remains the official language (government, education), while Hausa, Yoruba, Igbo, and Fulfulde serve as major regional lingua francas.

Major Festivals

- **Argungu Fishing Festival** (Kebbi State) — a bare-hand fishing competition, also featuring water sports and wrestling
- **Osun-Osogbo Festival** (Osun State) — annual worship of the Osun fertility goddess, held in August in Osogbo
- **New Yam Festival** — celebrated in multiple forms; e.g. by the Iggede people of Benue State every first week of September, and in Enugu every November with masquerade displays to usher in the new yam
- **Durbar Festival** — horse-mounted riders paying homage to the Emir during Sallah (Katsina, Kaduna, Kano)
- **Eyo Festival** and boat regattas (Lagos)
- **Olojo Festival** (Ile-Ife, Osun State)
- Various carnivals in Abuja, Calabar, and Rivers State

Note: Hausa fact worth memorizing: ~75% of Hausa speakers are NOT ethnically Hausa — a common exam trap.

Origins of the Major Ethnic Groups

Hausa-Fulani (North) — The Bayajidda Legend

The traditional origin story: a prince named Bayajidda travelled from Baghdad to Kanem-Bornu and eventually to Hausaland. He married the daughter of the Mai (ruler) of Bornu and had a son at Biran, then moved to Daura, where he helped kill a snake that had long prevented people from drawing water from the town well. Impressed, the Queen of Daura married him, and they had a son named Bawo.

Bawo's six sons (plus Bayajidda's earlier son at Biran) are traditionally credited as founders of the seven original Hausa states ("Hausa Bakwai"): Kano, Katsina, Zaria, Gobir, Rano, Daura, and Biram.

The Fulani

Ethnically and linguistically distinct from the Hausa. They call themselves Fulani and speak Fulfulde — known by other names elsewhere ("Peul" to the Wolof, "Fula" to the Bambara, "Felaata" in the Chad Basin). They settled among the Hausa in Sokoto, Katsina, Kano, Bornu, Bauchi, the Jos Plateau, and Adamawa Highlands; centuries of intermingling produced the term "Hausa-Fulani." Two broad categories exist: pastoral/cattle Fulani, and settled Fulani (Fulani Gida).

Yoruba (Southwest)

Samuel Johnson's 1950 book "History of the Yoruba" traces Yoruba origins to the North-Eastern area of Africa (Egypt), citing similarities in religious observance, art, and burial practices as evidence. He held that the Yoruba migrated from Egypt over many years before settling at Ile-Ife, with Oduduwa as the first leader, who then sent his sons and grandsons to found other Yoruba kingdoms — including Oyo, Benin, and others.

Note: A rival, more recent linguistic theory argues the name "Yoruba" was originally given to the Oyo people by northern neighbours (the Baatonu/Bariba of Borgu) rather than self-chosen. Worth knowing it exists, but Samuel Johnson's Egypt/Oduduwa account is the standard version expected in GST 112 exams.

Igbo (Southeast)

Origins traced to southeastern Nigeria, where the Igbo formed various autonomous city-states/village-groups before the colonial period, rather than migrating from elsewhere — consistent with their historically decentralized political structure (see Module 1 of the main summary).

Marriage and Family in Pre-Colonial Nigeria

Types of Marriage

- **Monogamy** — one husband, one wife
- **Polygyny** — widespread; in Yoruba society, wealthy men took multiple wives partly to display wealth and authority, since sustaining several households signalled prestige. Bride-wealth (yams, cloth, livestock) transferred reproductive and labour rights to the husband

- **Marriage by capture/elopement** — among the Ezinihitte (Igbo), a man could historically capture a maiden en route to/from market; if he got her home and fired a gunshot to announce it, she became his legitimate wife with no bridal payment required. Among the pre-colonial Tiv of Benue, elopement was a route to marriage when a father refused a suitor's request
- **Preferential/prescribed marriage** — cross-cousin marriage was practised and preferred in some cultures (notably the Fulani and Kanuri), while marriage between parallel cousins was forbidden; the Igbo had specific arrangements such as Mmaji and Njoku marriage

Functions of the Family

Beyond reproduction, the family provides affection and companionship — children develop a positive self-image through the warmth given within the family, while adults need intimate companionship to cope with life, together building a shared sense of belonging.

Colonial and Contemporary Impact

European colonial administration and Christianity pushed monogamy and discouraged polygamy as "primitive." The introduction of a cash economy made marriage more expensive, delaying it for many. In contemporary Nigeria, most marriages now blend traditional elements (engagement, bride price, traditional wedding ceremony) with civil/religious ones (marriage registry, church or mosque wedding) — which aspect is emphasized depends on the individuals involved, but the family as an institution remains central to Nigerian society.